changes in Muslim personal law as a progressive, developmental and gender-positive measure. Simultaneously, its base welcomed this particular change as yet another strike on what they saw as the political favouritism to minorities, or 'pseudo-secularism', that had been ushered in during the era of Congress hegemony.

The Owaisi Factor: 'F-Team to B-Team' and the Rise of a New Muslim Party

Asaduddin Owaisi's sprawling white mansion in Shastripuram, with its arched windows and white-pillared courtyards shaded with palm trees, spreads over several acres of a hillock. It has a splendid view of Hyderabad—a picturesque sweep across both Old Hyderabad, which his family lineage represents, as well as New Hyderabad, which his politics seeks to reshape. The four-time Hyderabad MP, barrister from London's Lincoln's Inn and president of the city's All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM, or the All India Council for the Unity of Muslims) has become the face of a new kind of Muslim politics and electoral response to the rise of the BJP.

When we drove up to his house to interview Owaisi on a sunny late-November day in 2018, he was in the middle of the Telangana election campaign. We had met earlier that day over a sumptuous free-wheeling biryani-and-kebabs lunch at TRS Working President K.T. Rama Rao's working office, and Owaisi had consented to meet us again for a formal interview.

The Hyderabad MP is a fascinating figure. A former fast bowler for the South Zone University cricket team,[35] he had once ridden into Telangana Chief Minister K. Chandrashekhar Rao's house on a Bullet motorcycle for a political meeting in December 2018.[36] Owaisi represents a party that traces its historical lineage to 1926, when it started political life as MIM, an outfit in the Nizam's Hyderabad. MIM was linked to the Nizam's Razakars, who had defied India's moves to integrate Hyderabad after Independence, and were banned in 1948 after 'Operation Polo', the Indian military action that ended the armed resistance. The party was then revived in 1957 by Abdul Wahed Owaisi, Asaduddin's grandfather, who restructured MIM into AIMIM after swearing allegiance to India's Constitution. The party